

Look, watch, hear, and listen

Learner workbook

Describe attention and perception.

Understand the distinction

Look at directs visual attention toward something. Watch usually involves attention over time, often to something changing or moving. Hear describes receiving sound; listen emphasizes paying attention to it.

Use to before the object of listen: listen to music. Hear does not need to before its object. The attention distinction is useful but not absolute: hear a speaker can also mean attend a talk. Learn familiar activity phrases such as watch television and look at a photo.

Compare the patterns

DIRECT ATTENTION

Look at this photo.

Turn your attention to it.

OVER TIME

We watched the match.

Follow an event as it develops.

SOUND

I heard music and stopped to listen to it.

The sound was perceived, then attended to.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: Please listen ___ the announcement.

2. Choose for a moving event: We ___ the game.

3. Correct this: I heard to a loud noise.

Use it in your own life

Describe a sound you noticed and what you then paid attention to.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. to

Listen takes to before the object.

2. watched

Watch is natural for following a game.

3. I heard a loud noise.

Hear takes the object directly.

One possible response

I heard a voice outside. I listened to the announcement.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-39.html